



THE CHALLENGERS
AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal at Gandhidham on Nov. 5, (left) Congress leader Rahul Gandhi campaigning in Surat on Nov. 21

ANI

finally enter politics and almost joined Congress, according to sources. Except that he did not, claiming that "the time is not right". Curiously, that announcement came right after he reportedly met Modi. Meanwhile, the BJP fielded the second-most powerful member of the SKTT, Ramesh Tilara, from the Rajkot (South) seat, much against the wishes of former BJP minister Govind Patel, who had won the seat comfortably in the previous election.

The Congress strategy in Gujarat, meanwhile, remains an enigma. Despite winning 77 seats in 2017, it failed to become a formidable opposition either in the assembly proceedings or in subsequent local polls, betraying the trust of its support base. Instead, it ceded ground to AAP rather lamely and allowed it to win 27 of the 120 seats in the Surat municipal polls. Strategy for the assembly polls this time has again been left to Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot, who played a significant role in the Congress's impressive showing in 2017.

Unlike the previous election when Rahul Gandhi led from the front and campaigned extensively in the state, he has preferred to continue with his Bharat Jodo Yatra, which inexplicably did not include Gujarat. He finally agreed to address two rallies, one at Anaval near Surat and the other at Rajkot. At Anaval, a town dominated by tribals, support for the Congress was evident from the crowds that had gathered to hear Rahul. But the Congress leader spent most of the time talking about the aims of his yatra and less on addressing key tribal issues. The Congress scion also does not have the advantage of being able to speak in Gujarati, and establish a natural connect that Modi can. It was when Rahul addressed tribal apprehensions over the possible takeover of their land for the Par-Tapi-Narmada river-linking project that he elicited the most cheers. The reason why the tribals resist the BJP is their apprehension that the party wants to take over their *jal, jangal* and *jameen* (water, forests and land) in the name of urban development and hand it over to corporates to exploit. In 2017, the BJP won just nine out of the 27 seats reserved for tribals, with the Congress bagging the most, 15, and the rest going to other parties.

This time, the BJP has assured tribals that the river-linking project has been put on hold. Modi also makes it a point to mention how his government has acknowledged the contribution of Adivasi icon Birsa Munda. Meanwhile, the RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh) affiliate Janjati Kalyan Ashram, has stepped up its activities in the 14 tribal districts of the state. However, poll experts believe the tribals are likely to continue backing the Congress this election. The RSS, which has 1,334 daily *shakhas* at taluka level, is also making constant efforts to reach out to Dalit communities in villages via their *samrast gaon* (synergised villages) programme. In the past year, *samrast yajnas* have been held in 1,000 villages, where all communities come together to pray. The RSS is also using this outreach to